



Accessibility and Inclusion Information Booklet

The Lake Erie Council is committed to making Scouting accessible and enjoyable to all Scouts, regardless of their abilities. Since its founding in 1910, the Scouting America has included fully participating members with physical, mental and emotional disabilities. Scouting America's policy is to treat members with disabilities as much like other members as possible. It has been traditional, however, to make some accommodations in advancements necessary. By adapting the environment and/or our instruction methods, most Scouts with disabilities can be successful in Scouting Only if truly needed, as demonstrated with a doctor's note and Council determination, are modifications of advancements and/or merit badge requirements made.

The basic premise of Scouting for youth with disabilities is full participation. Youth with disabilities can be treated and respected like every other member of their unit. They want to participate like other youth - and Scouting provides that opportunity. An individual is considered to have a "disability" if he or she:

- Has a physical or mental impairment that substantially limits one or more major life activities - seeing, hearing, speaking, walking, breathing, performing manual tasks, learning, caring for oneself and working.
- Has a record of such impairment & is regarded as having such an impairment.

There are many resources available to parents and leaders of Scouts with disabilities and special needs.

Guide to Working With Scouts with Special Needs and DisABILITIES, No. 510-071

BSA Disabilities Awareness - Serving Scouts with Disabilities webpage

Scouting for Youth with Disabilities Manual, No. 34059 Autism and Scouting Webpage

Guide to Advancement, Section 10, Advancement for Members with Special Needs

How can Units learn about the needs of every Scout?

Joining conferences are at the crux of a successful tenure in the Scouting program. Joining conferences are encouraged to be a regular practice for every new youth in your Unit, but is particularly important for a youth with known special needs. A joining conference builds trust and rapport among the leadership and the parents as partners in delivering the Scouting program. Every Scout has unique attributes. The joining conference can help the unit play to the strengths of the youth, provide for his/her special needs, and help prevent conflicts with other members of the unit. The joining conference should take place within the first month after the Scout joins the unit. Keep in mind this conference is not a “job interview,” as each youth has nothing to prove before joining a unit.

The joining conference should be a friendly, informative, get-to-know-you meeting. While listening and asking questions, it is critical to understand what is being said. The expertise of someone who has worked in the field of special needs can be very beneficial. Your council’s Disabilities Awareness Committee could be a resource for you at the time of the conference. Generally, parents want the leadership to know and understand the youth. Listen and ask questions. The parents will tell you what you need to know. Ultimately, the goal is to form a team with the parents in order to provide a growth oriented program. Keeping the lines of communication open should definitely be another goal. Begin with asking about strengths and then the struggles. Find out how the youth manages them. As a parent, find out how the leadership could help in specific circumstances. As a leader, find out how the parents handle and work with the youth. Work together to come up with doable solutions. Understanding a specific diagnosis can be helpful, but not a necessary component. The main goal should be for the leadership and the parents to work together for the success of the youth. Don’t stop with just this one conference. Keep an open door policy. Building relationships with the Scout and his/her family is critical and continual communication is paramount.

How Do I Register my New Scout as Having a Disability or Special Needs?

There is no special registration process for Scouts with a disability or special need or procedure to collect such information. Instead, the parents need to talk to Unit leaders about their son's or daughter's particular challenges. It is encouraged that all Units make it a practice to have joining conferences with every new family/member that joins, where important information, such as about disability status, can be collected early on. A good Unit can and does make simple accommodations for individual members whenever possible. If the youth has mobility or health restrictions that will affect camp activities, these are generally collected on the camp physical examination form. Camps don't necessarily share this information with the entire staff, so adult leaders may find it helpful to talk directly to camp staff about these restrictions. The disability/special needs status of a Scout or Venturers isn't otherwise relevant outside the unit unless the youth requires and qualifies for advancement accommodations or additional time to fulfill requirements.

What Advancement Flexibility is Allowed in Scouting?

The [Guide to Advancement](#) outlines advancement for Cub Scouts (10.2.1.0), Scouts BSA (10.2.2.0) and Venturers and Sea Scouts (10.2.3.0) with special needs. Most of the time, Scouts will not need any changes from advancement requirements as they are written. It is important to remember to carefully read requirements and to read them as literally as possible. The Guide to Advancement section 10 is clear in stating that “Members must meet current advancement requirements as written for merit badges, all ranks, and Eagle Palms—no more and no less—and they are to do exactly what is stated. Requirements have been carefully constructed so as not to unnecessarily restrict the format or method for completing a requirement. The convenience, preferences, or traditions of the person assessing the work must not add to the requirement. For example, a task that is usually done outdoors or on a campout does not necessarily have to be, unless specified in the requirement.” It is also shared that “Allowances for Scouts BSA members are made in three ways. The simplest is an open-minded reading of the requirement, after learning about the Scout and how the special need or disability affects that Scout. If the requirement can be met as written, but in an unconventional or creative way, that is sufficient.”

Cub Scouts, Scouts BSA, Venturers or Sea Scouts who have disabilities may qualify for limited flexibility in advancement. Allowances possible in each program are outlined below. It does not necessarily matter if a youth is approved to be registered beyond the age of eligibility. Experience tells us those members whose parents are involved, or at least regularly consulted, progress the farthest.

Accommodations vs. Modifications

Any Scout with needs is able to be provided an accommodation, by any adult. Scouts must be approved for any modifications -which change *what* is learned- by the submitting an application to Lake Erie Council.

	ACCOMMODATION	MODIFICATION (rare)
Definition	Change HOW Scouts are learning	Change WHAT Scouts are learning
Example	Offer extra time; take swim test at quieter time of day; allow assistive devices (glasses, hearing aids, augmentative and alternative communication devices, etc.)	Earn Pioneering merit badge instead of Camping merit badge
Who Can Approve	Unit-level decision, by Cubmaster, Scoutmaster, merit badge counselor	Council Advancement Committee
Documentation Required	None	Individual Scout Advancement Plan (rank) and/or Alternative Eagle Scout Rank Merit Badges Application

Individual Scout Advancement Plan

The [Individual Scout Advancement Plan](#) (ISAP), No. 512-936 is similar to an Individual Education Plan (IEP), which is used in schools to establish a student's special education eligibility. An ISAP is used within the Council and is specific to each Scout. It is usually prepared in a cooperative effort between parents, Scout leaders and a healthcare professional. The objective of an ISAP is to chart a course through the advancement program that helps a Scout or Venturer with disabilities achieve as much as any limitations will allow, and to facilitate applications for alternative requirements, merit badges and registration beyond the age of eligibility, as appropriate. Some Units might like to create a written, but more informal, Scout advancement plan to be used within just their Pack/Troop/Crew/Ship in order to help all Leaders and families know about supports and accommodations a Scout requires and finds most helpful. They might include supports the troop needs (eg if the troop needs a parent to attend camp with them to help out, for safety purposes, etc), outline behavioral expectations, etc.

Application for Alternate Eagle Scout Rank Merit Badges

In order to earn merit badges, Scouts must successfully complete all requirements as stated; no more, no less. Though this rule applies to Scouts with disabilities, some, because of the severity of their medical condition, are permitted to earn alternative badges in lieu of those required for the Eagle Scout rank. Section 10.2.2.3, "Alternative Merit Badges for Eagle Scout Rank", in the Guide to Advancement outlines the process. Scouts with special needs must first earn as many of the Eagle-required badges they are capable of earning before applying for any alternatives. With help from the parent or guardian and unit leader, the Scout's careful review of the requirements prior to starting work on an Eagle-required badge will help the Scout determine if the badge is attainable. If this isn't possible, the Scout should apply for approval to earn an alternative badge once he or she has completed all the other required ones. Planning ahead is the key. If the Scout qualifies, the parent or guardian and leader may proceed in helping the Scout apply for alternative merit badges early on so the [Application for Alternative Eagle Scout Rank Merit Badges](#), No. 512-730, can be completed and submitted on time. It should also be noted the alternative merit badge chosen must provide a similarly challenging experience as the required badge.

Registration Beyond the Age of Eligibility

Youth members with severe physical disabilities and youth and adults with developmental or cognitive challenges may be able to [Request Registration Beyond the Age of Eligibility](#), No.512-935, in Cub Scouts or Scouts BSA. This allows them to work through the advancement program at a pace appropriate to their needs. The steps to do this are relatively easy and you will find them outlined in section 10.2.2.4 of the [Guide to Advancement](#).

A collaboration of parents, Scout leaders and qualified health professionals need to complete the information that must be submitted to the local council for approval. This team should have a good understanding of the Scout's abilities and disabilities, and how these will affect his or her ability to complete requirements for advancement. The information submitted will help the council make a proper assessment, so preparers need to be sure to include as much detail as possible.

It is suggested that any Scout who qualifies should be registered this way as soon as possible so he or she has ample time to complete the requirements. The advancement program is challenging, but many members with disabilities have found ways to succeed. Providing them extra time to work on requirements and merit badges, when approved in advance, has proven to be helpful.

Resources:

Guide to Advancement - Advancement for Scouts with Special Needs

<https://filestore.scouting.org/filestore/pdf/gta-section-10.pdf>

No Scout Left Behind: A Guide to Working With Scouts With Disabilities Facebook Page

Guide to Working With Scouts With Disabilities

<https://www.scouting.org/resources/disabilities-awareness/>

Able Scouts Website - Articles on Scouting with Special Needs and Disabilities

<https://ablescouts.org/>

Inclusion Tool Box (Special Needs Training Modules)

<https://ablescouts.org/toolbox>

Individual Scout Advancement Plan

<https://filestore.scouting.org/filestore/pdf/512-936 WB.pdf>

Scouting with Special Needs and Disabilities Information Sheet

<https://filestore.scouting.org/filestore/pdf/SpecialNeedsInformationSheet.pdf>

Request for Registration Beyond the Age of Eligibility

<https://filestore.scouting.org/filestore/pdf/512-935 wb.pdf>

Application for Alternate Eagle Rank Merit Badges

<https://filestore.scouting.org/filestore/pdf/512-730.pdf>